X

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Tuning Fork

TWG-01

The Will of Gears

Tuning Fork

Lab, Suitcase

X: Fantastic, Regulus! I've tried this experiment so many times, but I've never had such amazing results!

X: You were the perfect fulcrum! I don't know what I would have done without you.

Regulus: Hmph, have I really surprised you, then? Hah, you've not even seen the best from this Captain yet!

Regulus: Check me out!

Regulus strikes the ball with her cue.

The ball rolls forward, coasting along blindly down an over-complicated track.

After an incomprehensible chain of further Goldberg reactions, including a toy fire engine and a bowl of spaghetti, the fuse, at last, ignites.

Sounding off a twenty-one gun salute in the laboratory, which naturally comes accompanied by a positively wicked rock guitar riff courtesy of Regulus.

Regulus: Easy as pie!

X: Splendid, Captain! This exper- ... This show of ours is ready to shock the world.

The two like-minded participants are quick to cheer their success.

Unfortunately, one person's honey can be another's vinegar.

And soon, it would not only be fireworks exploding inside the laboratory.

Mesmer Jr.: Just what in the hell have you been doing in here!

Mesmer Jr.: Why is there a toothbrush stuck in the conveyor belt??? A test tube rack hanging in the air??? A banana peel lying on dry ice??? And why, just why, are there rhinoceros horns in the disinfection cabinet???

X: Oh, please don't mind the mess, Mesmer. All in the name of science!

X: Regulus and I are just testing out some "new gadgets" ... a rehearsal for a new performance.

Mesmer Jr.: I'm sure I don't need to tell you just how many safety regulations you've violated. Not that you would care ...

Mesmer Jr.: And what exactly is the scientific aim you hope to achieve with this absurd contraption?

Regulus: Obviously, it's for the show—

X: Obviously, it's for mechanical science.

X: You might not be familiar with Rube Goldberg machines. Their constituent components may seem obtuse or unusual, but when combined, they produce results of remarkable precision.

Mesmer Jr.: Oh, indeed, like lighting a firework that you could reach by simply bending down.

X: Well, maybe ... But, it's the process that matters! Otherwise, why wouldn't we just die as soon as we're born?

Mesmer Jr.: I've never seen any viable scientific experiment involve a banana peel on dry ice.

X: Is science not about exploring the unknown?

As the argument begins to spiral up to its peak, Regulus could not help herself from cracking open a bottle of Dr. Papper.

Mesmer Jr.: I've had enough of these childish fancies! Useful mechanics must be concise and repeatable, not these hair-brained schemes you cook up in your imagination!!

X: Haha, that's only your own bias at work, Ms. Mesmer. Simple machines might work like that, but it's totally different with complicated systems.

Mesmer Jr.: With all due respect, these inventions of yours are nothing more than meaningless garbage. I suggest you dismantle this ... thing immediately, and return the laboratory to its original state.

X: My work is hardly useless. It reveals the hidden truths of the universe! Have you considered that life itself was born from a subtle Goldberg machine?

X: In the chaotic primordial soup, chemicals collided randomly, forming, by sheer precise coincidence, the foundations of cellular life.

X: Similarly, in my apparatus, spheres move repeatedly, eventually reaching a stable outcome. It's a transition from chaos to order ...

Regulus: Vertin, Vertin! Just in time! I figure they're about to start fighting any second!

Mesmer Jr.: Forget it!!

Mesmer Jr.: I thought the arcanists here would be ... normal! Must the Timekeeper always be surrounded by these ...

Choices

1. Did you call for me, Ms. Mesmer?

This has been a very bad time to arrive.

The atmosphere around Mesmer Jr. at this moment can only be compared to the sky during the Great Fire of London in 1666. Mere seconds away from inferno.

Mesmer Jr.: Never mind. You should know, I will be documenting my observations of this incident in a forthcoming report.

The professionalism of her words comes in sharp contrast with her barely-concealed rage as she storms off.

TO BE CONTINUED...

Potent Drugs

TWG-02

Potent Drugs

Letter: "In conclusion, Researcher X's continued study on mechanical devices poses significant safety risks ..."

Letter: "It is recommended that Researcher X undergo a thorough investigation for compliance, along with all of his mechanical devices ..."

Neat handwriting, clear argumentation. It makes for another fine addition to the pile of over thirty other similar complaints.

It seems Mesmer Jr. has put no small effort into her report. Now someone else has to work overtime to follow them through.

X: Relax! There are no safety concerns with any of my devices!

X: See, it will all run automatically as soon as you sit down here. And the result is ...

X: Aha, a flower!

Thankfully, the subject of her investigation is both cooperative and enthusiastic in demonstrating his work.

X: Next, let me present an experiment that uses marbles to turn off a set of lights after a thirty-minute delay! Oh, and then I'll have to show you my machine that uses matches and fishing line to automate watering plants! And then ...

Vertin: ...

X: Huh? Leaving so soon? There's still a ton of apparatuses and blueprints I haven't shown you yet!

A love of science is hard to criticize.

But excessive passion in any pursuit can spiral into catastrophe.

X: Are you certain you don't want to review my work again? This is a once-in-a-lifetime opportunity!

Sonetto: Uh ... Timekeeper?

Sonetto: You seem out of breath ...? Is someone chasing you?

Choices

1. Sonetto?

Sonetto: Sorry, Mesmer Jr. said you might be here. I just came to check in.

Sonetto: Did I ... disturb you?

In fact, she has arrived just in time. Unfortunately, so does another.

X: Hey, Vertin! Where were you off to? I thought you and I were supposed to be having fun doing a "systemic review" of my work.

Sonetto: Hello, Mr. X.

X: Oh, hi, Ms. Sonetto!

X: I suppose your being here must mean we have a new mission?

Sonetto: Precisely. The Foundation needs us to relocate an arcanist to headquarters before the "Storm."

Sonetto: The risk for this operation is relatively low. Timekeeper, you've been given free rein to designate your team members for this task.

Sonetto: It does seem that this mission's target is rather tricky. Madam Z suggests that you bring along a team member who excels at communication ...

X: Hey, why are you looking at me like that?

X: I can't believe you dragged me out here.

X: I'd love to help, but you know field missions aren't my strong suit. I'm more of a laboratory rat, you know?

Choices

1. You won't be going back to the laboratory before the investigation ends.

X: Yes, yes, yes ... I will do whatever I can to assist!

X: But aren't most arcanists known for their difficult personalities? What's so special about this guy?

Sonetto flips through the mission book.

Sonetto: Our target is Vlad Wilson. Born into a family of potion-makers, he is currently the sole owner of Wilson Pharmaceuticals. It also says he seems to be tied up in some kind of medical dispute.

Sonetto: You're originally American, aren't you, Mr. X? Are you familiar with the name?

X: Uhm ... I grew up in the slums, Sonetto. Not really the kind of place you just bump into pharmaceutical moguls.

X: Really, I don't see how I can help with this mission.

X: Maybe you should consider grabbing someone else? I can head back.

Choices

1. We could let you out here, if you'd like.

2. I caution you to remember the subject of your laboratory privileges.

Branch 1

X: No, no, I didn't mean it that way ... Please don't kick me out in the middle of nowhere.

Branch 2

X: Of course. Aha, I was only joking.

Shared continuation

X: Hm ... So back to the case, how did he get into this medical dispute? As far as lawsuits go, I've heard these types of cases are notoriously tough.

X: Got any more information in that book of yours?

Sonetto: The details of the dispute were not included in the mission book, nor did Madam Z say anything. Perhaps it is a personal matter for Mr. Wilson.

Sonetto: It is immaterial to our mission. We only need to coordinate with him about the transfer.

X: Yes, I just hope things go smoothly.

The car comes to a sudden stop. Still a long distance to go to the target location.

Sonetto: What is it? An ambush?!

X: No, it seems to be a protest.

Someone bangs on the car window frantically.

Crowd: Boycott Wilson Pharmaceuticals!

Crowd: Stop the patent acquisition!!! Give us back our medication!!!

Crowd: Wilson Pharmaceuticals is a price-gouging monster!!!

Though they move to roll up the windows, streams of flyers are pushed in before it closes up entirely.

X: Oh ... You were right, Ms. Sonetto. This whole medical dispute doesn't seem to have anything to do with our mission or arcanum in general.

X: But I think I've figured out what makes this Wilson guy so tricky.

X: Take a look for yourself.

Sonetto takes the flyer.

Sonetto: Vlad Wilson recently listed 49 drug patents for sale ... One of which is the only treatment for a copper metabolism disorder ...

Sonetto: And if the proposed sale goes through ... The price will be increased from $1 per capsule to ...

Sonetto: $550?!

TO BE CONTINUED...

The Matthew Effect

TWG-03

The Matthew Effect

Wilson: Well, what are you worried about?

Wilson: We own the patent, so what we charge for it is our right! Doesn't matter whether it's sold for $1 or $1000. It's none of their d**ned business.

Wilson: Let the whiners whine all they like. The law is on our side!

Wilson: Well, I'm not going to delay this signing any longer. If you don't want to set this thing to my price, then I can always sell the patent to the Brits instead. You get me?

Wilson Company Office

He slams the phone down.

Sonetto, waiting patiently, at last seizes the opportunity to speak.

Sonetto: Mr. Wilson, we are investigators from the St. Pavlov Foundation. As per the contract, please return to headquarters with us.

Wilson: Yeah ... Of course. I fully intend on complying with the Foundation.

Wilson: But first I need to take care of some company business. As you can see, I'm in a "little pickle," and things are far from settled here.

Wilson: You'll just have to wait a few days more until this contract is finalized.

Wilson: Don't worry about it. You and your little investigators can put your feet up and relax. We'll be fully covering your travel expenses while you wait.

Sonetto: But ...

Choices

1. This isn't what we originally agreed to, Mr. Wilson.

X: That's right, Mr. Wilson. More importantly, the "Storm" does not wait.

Wilson: Think I don't know that? That's why I've got to hurry up and sell these patents.

Wilson: Anyway, it's not like you've got any choice in the matter. Or didn't you read the rider?

Wilson smiles sharply.

X casts a confused glance at Sonetto.

Sonetto: ... There is indeed a clause. 17.2.2: The Foundation is required to assist in the transfer of property from Wilson Pharmaceuticals ...

Sonetto: We will fulfill our obligations.

Sonetto: But Mr. Wilson, if the "Storm" comes, it will be too late.

Wilson: Relax, little Miss Foundation. It won't take long.

Wilson: After my acquisition is complete, I'll honor the contract. I've got my reasons for this, you'll see.

Wilson: Till then, I've got work to do. Now, get out of here. Go make yourselves comfortable.

The protesters are still marching outside the office building.

Passerby: Cancel this sale! Protect patient rights!!!

X rolls up the window.

X: This Wilson guy is pretty smart. I can't believe he got us to sign that rider with the Foundation.

Choices

1. Do we just keep waiting like this?

Sonetto: Timekeeper, I do understand your concern.

Sonetto: But according to the terms of the rider, all we can do now is wait.

X: But Mr. Wilson didn't even give us a definitive timeline.

X: What are we going to do? Just wait around until the very last moment before the "Storm"?

Sonetto: That won't be necessary.

Sonetto: If need be, I'll ask headquarters for permission to transfer him forcibly.

X: I'm not sure if that will do much to help.

X: Seems like headquarters was fully aware of Wilson's "little pickle." But they still chose to make this agreement with him.

X: ... Hmm, I see. Haha, so that's how it is.

X: Ms. Sonetto, I think we've misunderstood the true purpose of our mission.

Sonetto: What do you mean?

X: Sure, Wilson is an arcanist, but he's a businessman first.

X: He is just trying to seek the best outcome for his interests.

X: So, after learning about the "Storm," he chose to join up with the Foundation. But he also chose to sell off his patents, and he's aiming on getting the most he can.

X: Of course, he had to expect that this would cause a lot of trouble. But as long as he's the rightful patent owner, he can sell it to anyone and for any price.

X: Then, he prepared his own retreat.

Choices

1. So we're here as security?

X: Mm-hm. You've got it, Ms. Vertin. He knew the Foundation would send someone to pick him up; he also knew he could make them stick around using the rider.

X: So if the situation deteriorates any further, he'll be able to use us as his shield.

Sonetto: Mr. X, what do you mean ...?

X: Think about it ...

X: Might he not, for example ... make us suppress a riot, if it becomes a threat?

Sonetto: ... Ridiculous!

Sonetto: We will, of course, ensure Mr. Wilson's personal safety, but we are under no obligation to follow his orders.

X: Ms. Sonetto, I can see why Madam Z warned you about this mission.

X: The moment you said "Of course," you fell into his trap.

Sonetto: I don't understand ...?

Choices

1. Like it or not, he intends to make this part of our mission.

X: Yes. Just follow the chain of events. All he will need to do is demonstrate that it is our job to "assist in the transfer of property" and "protect the mission target," and on principle, we cannot refuse him.

Choices

1. But the contract says nothing about suppressing riots.

X: So then the next part is clear. We've got to find a break in the chain and exploit it, before he passes that buck on to us.

X: Huh? Why are you all looking at me like that?

Sonetto: Sorry, your analysis was so reasonable that I almost lost my train of thought.

Choices

1. Seems like we must entrust this next part to you, X.

X: Wait, are we starting to pass the buck already?

X: Well, I can probably keep him safe ... But I'm not sure if I'm the right person for the job.

Sonetto: Of course you are, Mr. X, and I must say it is truly an honor to be on this mission with you.

Sonetto: Your insight has been most invaluable to our mission. Truly.

Well, this mission just went from bad to worse.

X: ... I'd better get out of here before you two find more work to give me.

X: See you later, my heartless friends.

TO BE CONTINUED...

The Kids

TWG-04

The Kids

There's never much fun in waiting around.

But I'll say one thing for her: She never wastes time.

Sonetto: Morning, Timekeeper. Did you happen to see Mr. X?

Choices

1. Weren't you two just together?

Sonetto: Yes, but after we left Mr. Wilson's office, X suddenly claimed he had to get some coffee ...

Sonetto: But when I went to check, he wasn't in the cafe downstairs.

Sonetto: I was hoping to ask him to go over the rider again and perhaps draw up a formal proposal ...

Choices

1. Could you use my help instead?

Sonetto: Oh, no, no, please, Timekeeper, leave the paperwork to your capable assistant.

Sonetto: But, if you do have time, could I trouble you to help me find Mr. X?

Underground Parking Lot

Finding X is not hard.

One only needs to consider where someone would go when they're trying to dodge work—somewhere spacious, quiet, and off the beaten track.

X: Okay, one more wire to go ...

X: Who wants to provide our final lucky wire?

Children: Me, me!

X finds himself in an old garage, one he has set up in near to the protesters. And in front of him now stands a rudimentary Rube Goldberg machine.

So far, it consists of marbles, wires, rusty horns, a sprinkler, and a bucket with the bottom missing—household junk.

Before him, a group of kids from the protest gather around, looking at the contraption in amazement.

X: Thanks to everyone's enthusiastic support, our "Fully Automatic Marble Launcher" is finally ready!

X: Simply adjust the machine to the desired angle and press this spring ... Then we can enjoy a marvelous flying marble show!

X: Who wants to go first?

The children eagerly raise their hands. One little girl is particularly loud in her excitement.

X: Mm-hm, ladies first. Let's let Sophie, our prized bucket sponsor, come up and take our maiden flight!

Sophie: Haha! I told you I'd get you back for spraying me with that sprinkler!

Sophie lets out a vindictive laugh as she turns the machine toward her companion and presses the spring down smugly.

The marble bursts up and outwards, rolling around inside the bottomless bucket three times, and then flings out high into the air.

Traveling through the rusty horn, before it lands right back ... where it started.

Sophie: ...

Children: ...

X: Beautiful! An unmitigated success, Sophie.

X: You see, no matter what angle you set it at, the marble will always return to its original position.

X: A truly epic invention—a Fully Automated Marble Launcher which self-resets for unlimited use!

X begins to clap for himself. The response is an overwhelming chorus of boos from the kids.

Sophie: Hey, what's this all about, mister! You promised me that marble would fly 30 feet!

X: In fact, I promised that the vertical flight distance would be 30 meters...

Sophie: And what about the "precise targeting"? It didn't even hit 'em!

X: A marble falling back into its exact starting position is the very definition of precise targeting!

Sophie: If I'd known it was just gonna do that, I never would have given you the bucket!

The kids start into an uproar as loud as the protests outside.

Mixed in are shouts of "Make a better one," "Give me back my sprinkler," and "I'm telling my mom that you're a weirdo!"

Choices

1. The atmosphere here is electric, to say the least.

Sonetto: Is Mr. X ... putting on some kind of performance for these children?

Sonetto: He seems to be enjoying it.

X: ...?!

X: Oh! Vertin, Ms. Sonetto?! When did you get here ...?

Sonetto: Don't be so nervous, Mr. X. The Timekeeper just wants to see your latest performance.

Sonetto: Right, so what is this ... "Sprinkler" she just mentioned?

Little Girl: It's the most fun machine in the whole world! It made Sophie cry and call for her mom!

Sophie: Nuh-uh! I wasn't crying! That was just water! Water!

Choices

1. Looks like there was quite a showdown here.

X: Don't look at me like that. I solemnly swear that this machine was carefully designed to avoid any risk of harm.

X: I can explain this.

As X begins to speak, several calling voices are heard in the distance.

Little Girl: Ah, that's my mom! Guess it's time for my medicine ... again.

Sophie: Yeah, my dad says we've got to leave soon. So, wanna meet up and play here tomorrow?

Little Girl: I dunno ... Mom said she might have to take me back to the hospital, but only if "Mr. Wilson grows a heart" ...

Sophie: That sucks ...

Sophie: Why do we gotta be sick? It'd be cool if we could just wind up a spring and reset like this weirdo's toy ...

X: Hm? Thought you said you didn't like my Automatic Marble Launcher.

Sophie: Yeah, cause—I—don't—! I'm going home. You can keep the broken bucket, Mr. Weirdo!

The children begin to leave, heading back towards their waiting parents.

Sonetto: Who were those kids ...?

X: They're all children with congenital copper metabolism disorder.

X: I'll explain—but just wait a sec.

X lets out a sigh and begins to dismantle his contraption, carefully removing each of the different donated pieces.

X: I'll be just a minute.

TO BE CONTINUED...

Starting Point, End Point

TWG-05

Starting Point, End Point

Sonetto: So, then, their parents are the protesters we encountered at the march ...

X: Yes. Their parents have been protesting outside Wilson Pharmaceuticals for days now. So I offered to watch their kids.

X: I wanted to give these kids a bit of a break—make something fun for them, you know?

X: A lot of them have been in and out of hospitals for a long time, so I thought they could use something to lift their spirits.

X: Hopefully, they'll never have to know why their parents were protesting.

Choices

1. So you decided to make a toy for them?

X: Oh, it wasn't just a toy.

X: I prefer to describe it as a project.

Sonetto: It seems you're very passionate about this project.

Sonetto: Mr. X, it was very kind of you to create such an ... amusement for these children.

Choices

1. But there's another angle to it: You got them involved.

X: A sense of involvement is important for attracting an audience.

Choices

1. But your investors protested the product didn't meet expectations?

X: Well, I can't help that. I can't just let little kids run around with a marble launcher that just shoots off anywhere, now can I?

X: Still, seems like I'm not so good at building a "respectable" rapport with these kids.

Sonetto: You sell yourself short, Mr. X. It's plainly clear they like you.

X: Aha, well, I appreciate your confidence.

X: The way they play reminds me a lot of the other kids, who played in the orphanage growing up.

Sonetto: Orphanage ...?

X: Yes, it's a bit different from growing up in the St. Pavlov Foundation, like you did.

X: Back then, I had lots of siblings. I would often make machines like this. I'd get them to invest too ...

X: But later ...

Sonetto: Oh no, did something happen?

X: —I joined the Foundation, and well, frankly, it's hard to find the same sort of investors there.

Choices

1. Is that so?

X: Of course. My brothers and sisters back then would give me anything I needed, just to see what I'd make. But when it comes to convincing adults, like Laplace and Mesmer ... They're not so eager, especially that overbearing complainer.

Sonetto: Hmm, what was that about Ms. Mesmer?

X: Oh. Nothing, nothing. She's a fine colleague.

Sonetto: Oh, perhaps I heard you wrong.

Sonetto: But what Sophie just said does remind me of something Ms. Mesmer Jr. has said about mankind.

Sonetto: "One only needs to press the button to activate the feature. The toggle switch connects the circuits ..."

Sonetto: "If only the human condition could be repaired like a machine."

X: Ms. Sonetto ... do you realize that's an excellent proposition on mechanical theory?

Sonetto: What do you mean? I'm afraid I don't know anything at all about mechanical theory ...

X: No, no. What you just quoted, or should I say, "proposed," is precisely what lies at the heart of the LSCC's ethos.

X: "If we know the state of the universe at some initial time, we can determine its state at any other time."

X: The ultimate goal of the LSCC is to build an omniscient, intelligent machine capable of doing just that.

Sonetto: Is that so ... That would be an amazing feat!

X: But I'm afraid this would still not achieve Ms. Mesmer's ideal.

X: Ms. Sonetto, if society were to behave like a perfect machine, and each element would follow a precise and predictable orbit. What would determine who benefits from the system and who doesn't?

Sonetto: The system ...?

X: The initial point.

X: Because in a measured orbit, everything is predetermined. So we only need to calculate the initial position of any one part to calculate all its states from past to future in the orbit.

X: Therefore, if the ball is set to move from point A to point B, then it might be that wealth is destined to flow from the poor to the rich.

X: And because the system is so designed that only those who pay get treatment, so individuals with higher starting points will receive the greater benefits.

X: It's a rational system and a legal one, for now. No surprises and no miracles.

Sonetto: ...

Choices

1. You seem to be confusing social systems for mechanistic ones.

X: Fundamentally, there is no difference between humans and machines.

X: Oh, I apologize, I've gone off-topic ... Ms. Sonetto, would you mind helping me clean this up?

Sonetto: Happy to help!

Sonetto: But what did you mean by "the initial point?"

TO BE CONTINUED...

Gravitational Potential

TWG-06

Gravitational Potential

Mr. Wilson's patent transfer has been delayed now for three days. Today is the last day to sign.

Sonetto: According to the agreement, we will transfer Mr. Wilson to headquarters immediately after the contract is signed.

Sonetto: But now ...

Protester: Price gougers kill!!! Give us back our money!!!

Police: Back! Get back!!

A raging protest surrounds the Wilson Pharmaceuticals building, waiting for his car to depart.

Once the contract is signed, the only effective drug for a serious copper metabolism disorder will rise from $1 to $550.

For both sides, this seems to be their last chance.

Male Clerk: Hello, are you from the St. Pavlov Foundation? We're with Mr. Wilson.

Male Clerk: We'd like to ask you to accompany us to the signing location to keep things under control.

Choices

1. I'm sure you understand that is not our responsibility.

Male Clerk: According to the rider you signed with Mr. Wilson, the Foundation must assist Wilson Pharmaceuticals in the transfer of all property. These patents are the company's property.

Male Clerk: Please understand, we are only asking you to act in accordance with the contract.

Sonetto: I understand. We will do what we must to assist you.

Choices

1. Sonetto?

Male Clerk: Just you, Miss?

Sonetto: Nowhere in the contract does it specify the number of people that must be present during this transfer.

Sonetto: The Timekeeper has more important tasks, so this obligation will be fulfilled by me as her assistant.

Male Clerk: Of course, I'm certain we can trust in your capabilities as an agent of the St. Pavlov Foundation.

Male Clerk: Please follow me.

Choices

1. ...

Sonetto: Not to worry, Timekeeper. I'll decide whether it is necessary to activate our emergency plan to protect Mr. Wilson as the situation develops.

Sonetto: You and Mr. X should take this time to make preparations for the transfer.

Sonetto and the clerks from Wilson Pharmaceuticals take their leave.

Everything is proceeding just as X said it would, yet the prophet himself is not present.

Instead, on the roof of an abandoned high-rise building, a lone figure stands against the wind.

X: ...

X: "If there is an intelligence that can understand all the forces that bring vitality to nature ..."

X: "And all the elements and things that constitute nature and their current states ..."

X: "And this intelligence is great enough to analyze all this data ..."

X: "Then from the largest object in the universe to the smallest particle, the movements of every body in time and space can be encompassed in the same formula ..."

X: "For this intelligence, nothing is uncertain. The future will unwind before it with the same certainty that the past does."

The wind rustles the pages of the book.

X: What a beautiful discourse, Mr. Laplace.

X: It's just a pity ... The butterfly has already flapped its wings.

X: When you were erecting that perfect machine, did you ever think that even the smallest gears might have a will of their own?

The protesters are gathered in front of Wilson Pharmaceuticals.

The rage of the crowd is growing to a fever pitch.

Crowd: Down with Wilson!!! Wilson has blood on his hands.

Security Guard: D**n it, we won't be able to get out ...!

Sonetto: Allow me.

Sonetto: Sonetto takes a deep breath.

Sonetto: May the peace be with us.

Then, she lifts her arms high—

Sonetto: Via Pellar!

A simple and harmless arcane skill.

It grants a blessing to the road, so that Wilson's car is able to safely drive away despite the crowds.

The headlights come on. Everyone can only watch as Wilson's car speeds away, harmlessly passing through the crowd.

Wilson: Useless whiners, what do these idiots know ...?

Wilson: It costs money to go to London, to develop a drug, to avoid the "Storm," to come back ... Everything costs money.

Wilson: Besides, why should I care about things like ethics when the "Storm" is about to wash away everything?

Wilson: I don't have time for this. Get out of the way, you stupid bastard!

Wilson pushes his driver out, taking the wheel of his car and slamming on the gas pedal.

Sonetto: ...!?

Choices

1. Sonetto!

The smoke disperses.

The crowd has instinctively retreated from the crash, forming a large circle.

Smoke billows out from Wilson's black car. It has crumpled up like a crushed soda can.

A sudden and unexpected accident.

Sonetto: ...!

Crowd: ... Oh My God ...!

Crowd: Wilson is dead!!!

Crowd: He was crushed by his own company's sign falling down!!

Crowd: Seems like God finally took an interest! Hallelujah!

Sonetto: How could this have happened ...?

Choices

1. ...

Perhaps it is only a momentary illusion. But it seems to Vertin that she has spied the fluctuation of an arcane skill not far way on an abandoned high-rise.

Yet, a second look confirms there is no one to be seen.

TO BE CONTINUED...

Silent Machine

TWG-07

Silent Machine

Hallway, Foundation

Sonetto: I'm terribly sorry, Timekeeper. We've failed our mission. I should have done something sooner ...

Choices

1. This wasn't your fault, Sonetto.

2. I'm afraid it was completely unavoidable.

Shared continuation

Sonetto: No, no need to comfort me, Timekeeper. I'm prepared to take full responsibility.

Messenger: Sonetto!

Sonetto: ... Yes!

Sonetto: Well, I'm going in.

Sonetto disappears through the door to the interrogation room.

X: Ah, I should have expected we'd fall into some trouble when we returned to the Foundation.

X: Seems like I'm not cut out for field missions.

Choices

1. Is that really the story you're going with?

X: What? We haven't even entered the interrogation room, and you're already starting to question me?

Choices

1. Don't change the subject, Mr. X.

X: Fine. But before you begin, let me ask first ...

X: What makes you think I did anything?

Choices

1. Your absence at the scene was noted. Convenient, even—

X: I was just playing games with the kids. You read the report.

X: I'm sure you'll find they all passed the Lie Detector test that was administered, verifying my whereabouts at the time.

Choices

1. Sound of gears was heard at the crime scene.

X: And I'm sure you also read that the report concluded that there was a loose part on the sign. As for gears, come on, it's New York. That could have been anything!

Choices

1. It's easy to fake an accident with Goldberg Machine.

X: All of life is a Rube Goldberg machine. The only question is the outcome, and the initial point.

X: But you're asking "Did I make it." If I did, where was its fulcrum? There wasn't any trace of a machine at the scene.

Choices

1. ...

Thoughts begin to race.

Ultimately, X is the common feature of every Goldberg apparatus ...

From Regulus's firework lighting cue.

To Sophie's marble launching spring.

Human action is the initial point for every mechanical device. The participants themselves are a part of the experiment. Their behavior, their actions, engineered as a part of the machine.

Stable, controllable, and able to follow instructions.

Sonetto: Via Pellar!

Choices

1. Your fulcrum was a person.

Choices

1. You used her. You used Sonetto.

X: I don't know what you could possibly mean.

X: We both know I wasn't there. So how could I have controlled Ms. Sonetto's actions?

X: Are you trying to say that Ms. Sonetto acted as my accomplice?

X: That's a very serious accusation, wouldn't you say?

Choices

1. ... You!

Messenger: Vertin!

X: Tsk, they're calling you, Vertin.

X: Maybe we can talk more after this?

Interrogation Room

Inquisitor: So, do you have any additional information to add about the incident? Anything that could help would be welcome, Timekeeper.

Inquisitor: Please answer honestly.

Silence.

At first, the choice to speak up would have only implicated one person.

But that is no longer the case.

Choices

1. I have shared all the information I know.

Inquisitor: I understand. Thank you for your cooperation.

The wait for the verdict drags on, a sword hanging over the heads of two friends, dangling on a thread.

Finally ...

Sonetto: Timekeeper! Great! I've been looking for you!

Sonetto: I'm to inform you that the Foundation has dismissed their investigation.

Choices

1. Dismissed?

Sonetto: The results from the crime scene found no trace of unexpected arcane activity. The case has been officially ruled an accident.

Sonetto: Still, I'm planning on staying late at the Foundation, so I can volunteer for the very next mission. I must rectify this blot on our record!

Sonetto: Are you leaving?

Choices

1. Yes. I have something to take care of.

Sonetto: Oh, alright. Well ... See you soon.

Sonetto: By the way, it seems like the patent acquisition was terminated after Mr. Wilson's accident. So, it seems the price of the drug will remain $1!

Could this truly have been God's will?

Or perhaps it was there a Devil in the machine?

X: You look angry.

Choices

1. Did you know—Did you see this coming?

X: You're overestimating my skills, Ms. Vertin.

X: Arcanists are good with intuitive insight, and humans are good with logic-based deduction.

X: When the two compete against each other, they might turn a blind eye to the absurdity and chaos that is the world and what happens to certain people in it.

Choices

1. ...

X: Vertin, I am sorry about the accident.

X: But "the rain falls on the just and the unjust alike," isn't that what they say?

X: Arcanists and humans, the poor and the rich. As long as we all walk this earth, we're all the same.

X: That's just how the world works.

Choices

1. So, are we all just cogs in the machine to you?

X: When the marble is set, it doesn't really matter who triggers the spring. Its flight and its target will always be the same.

X: In fact, when you consider the mechanistic nature of reality, we're all cogs of one kind or another.

Choices

1. But you used your friend. My friend.

Choices

1. You used her.

X: That's why you're upset? ... Hm, well, I understand.

X: Don't worry ... I promise you won't see anymore "devices that pose safety risks" in the laboratory after this.

X turns to leave, but stops again.

X: —Oh, now that their investigation is over, would you mind if I took some of these letters off your hands?

The mechanical expert smiles, waving the documents back at her before disappearing through the laboratory doorway.

The fireplace burns low and quiet.

X: "... In conclusion, Researcher X's study on mechanical devices poses significant safety risks ..."

X: "Which, through unintended consequences, might result in damages, including but not limited to burns, collisions, disabilities, death, etc."

X takes a sip of his coffee, marveling with pride at the words as he raises the letter into the air.

X: A marvelous insight. These machines certainly have their dangers.

X: Burning ... That certainly is a risk.

X taps the edge of his cup, beginning a series of outrageous mechanical movements, as Mesmer's stack of complaints is pulled one by one from his desk and funneled into the fireplace.

Where they turn to ash, leaving not a single trace.

THE END